

Paper 2: Period study and British depth study

Overview

The relevant pages of this section specify the content that must be taught for the chosen option. All of the content for the option is mandatory.

Students are required to study **one** British depth study **and** one period study. The two parts are independent and so any depth study can be combined with any period study.

British depth studies (pages 22–29)

The depth studies focus on a substantial and coherent short time span and require students to understand the complexity of a society or historical situation and the interplay of different aspects within it. Depending on the depth study chosen, these may include social, economic, political, religious and military aspects.

The content is divided into three key topics. These provide a framework for teaching and understanding the option, but should not be taken in isolation from each other. For each depth study, there is some chronological overlap between key topics – this structure helps highlight the complexity and interplay of different aspects within society.

Assessment

Students will be assessed on their knowledge and understanding. Questions will target key features and causation, and may also target other second order concepts (change, continuity, consequence, similarity, difference, significance).

Period studies (pages 30–39)

The period studies focus on a substantial and coherent medium time span of at least 50 years and require students to understand the unfolding narrative of substantial developments and issues associated with the period.

The content is divided into three key topics, which provide a framework for teaching and understanding the option. These run in chronological sequence, but should not be taken in isolation from each other – students should appreciate the narrative connections that run across the key topics.

Assessment

Students will be assessed on their knowledge and understanding. Questions will target: consequence; significance (of specified events in relation to situations and unfolding developments); and analytical narrative (requiring students not only to describe what happened, but also to analyse events to find connections that explain the way in which events unfolded).

British depth studies

Option B1: Anglo-Saxon and Norman England, c1060–88

Key topic 1: Anglo-Saxon England and the Norman Conquest, 1060–66	
1 Anglo-Saxon government, economy and society	• Monarchy and government. The power of the English monarchy. Earldoms, local government and the legal system. • The economy and social system. Towns and villages. The influence of the Church.
2 The last years of Edward the Confessor and the succession crisis	• The significance and power of the house of Godwin. Harold Godwinson's succession as Earl of Wessex. • Harold Godwinson's embassy to Normandy. The reasons for the rising against Tostig and his exile. The death of Edward the Confessor.
3 The rival claimants for the throne	• The motives and claims of William of Normandy, Harald Hardrada and Edgar the Aethling. • The Witan and the coronation and reign of Harold Godwinson. • Reasons for, and significance of, the outcome of the battles of Gate Fulford and Stamford Bridge.
4 The Norman invasion	• The Battle of Hastings. • Reasons for William's victory, including the leadership skills of Harold and William, Norman and English troops and tactics.
Key topic 2: William I in power: securing the kingdom, 1066–87	
1 Establishing control	• The submission of the earls, 1066. • Rewarding followers and establishing control on the borderlands through the use of earls. The Marcher earldoms. • Reasons for the building of castles; their key features and importance.
2 Anglo-Saxon resistance, 1068–71	• Causes and outcomes of Anglo-Saxon resistance: the revolt of Earls Edwin and Morcar (1068); Edgar the Aethling and the rebellions in the North (1069); Hereward the Wake and rebellion at Ely (1070–71).
3 The legacy of resistance to 1087	• The reasons for and features of Harrying of the North (1069–70). Its immediate and long-term impact, 1069–87. • Changes in landownership from Anglo-Saxon to Norman, 1066–87.
4 Revolt of the Earls, 1075	• Reasons for and features of the revolt. • The defeat of the revolt and its effects.

Key topic 3: Norman England, 1066–88

1 The feudal system and the Church	• The feudal hierarchy. The role and importance of tenants-in-chief and knights. The nature of feudalism (landholding, homage, knight service, labour service); forfeiture. • The Church in England: its role in society and relationship to government, including the significance of Stigand and Lanfranc. The Normanisation and reform of the Church in the reign of William I. • The extent of change to Anglo-Saxon society and economy.
2 Norman government	• Changes to government after the Conquest. Centralised power and the limited use of earls under William I. The role of regents during William's absences. • The office of sheriff and the demesne. Introduction and significance of the 'forest'. • The Domesday survey and Domesday Book and their significance for Norman government and finance.
3 The Norman aristocracy	• The culture and language of the Norman aristocracy. • The career and significance of Bishop Odo.